

Buddhist art

After renouncing a life of luxury, replacing it with good thoughts, and achieving nirvana or enlightenment, Siddhartha Gautama (c.563–483 BCE) became the founder of Buddhism. After his death, his teaching spread across Asia from his birthplace in northern India. The earliest Buddhist art represented the Buddha's presence by a sign such as a pair of footprints, or an empty space beneath a parasol. In the first century CE, human representations became more common, but his appearance differed in different places, in paintings and stone or stucco statues. Some Buddhas with wavy curls and draped clothing resembled Roman statues of Apollo, others were plump and jolly.

Particular themes also appeared frequently, including events from Buddha's life, and from his previous lives (of which there were believed to be 550). Some time between the fourth and sixth centuries, an 'ideal image' of the Buddha was created in northern India, achieved by combining elements from different locations.



Buddha in Cambodian Phnom style, c.17th century